

CORE FORMULA

Open -> Affirm -> Reflect -> Summarise: pick the one move the moment needs. -> **Open:** "What matters most to you about this?" -> **Affirm:** "You have clearly put real thought into this." -> **Reflect:** "So it sounds like the timing is the real sticking point." -> **Summarise:** "Let me pull that together and check I have it right." -> **Field rule:** use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Pick the single OARS move the moment needs — an open question, an affirmation, a reflection or a summary — and say it in plain words, without naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Coaching and mentoring conversations
- Supportive chats where someone is thinking a problem through
- Behaviour-change and decision conversations
- Autonomy-sensitive moments where advice would land badly
- Helping someone who is talking in circles get unstuck
- Structuring your own response so it is easier to follow
- Feedback, once you know what kind of feedback would help

PHRASE BANK

Open questions (O) · Invite them to think

- "What matters most to you about this?"
- "How would you like this to go?"
- "What have you already tried?"
- "What is making this a hard call?"
- "What would a good outcome look like for you?"
- "Where would you like to start?"
- "What is the part you keep coming back to?"
- "What would need to be true for this to work?"

Affirmations (A) · Genuine recognition

- "You have clearly put real thought into this."
- "That took some courage to raise."
- "You have handled harder than this before."
- "You care about getting this right — it shows."
- "You worked through that carefully before deciding."
- "It says something that you are even asking the question."
- "You stuck with it when it got messy."

Reflections (R) · Say back what you heard

- "So it sounds like the timing is the real sticking point."
- "You are saying the work is not the problem — the workload is."
- "It seems like you are keener than you are letting on."
- "What I am hearing is that fairness matters more than speed here."
- "So part of this is excitement and part of it is nerves."

- "Let me make sure I have it: you want in, just not yet."

Summaries (S) · Tie the threads together

- "Let me pull that together and check I have it right."
- "So the main things are the cost, the timing and the team — anything missing?"
- "Where we have landed is X. Does that match how you see it?"
- "To sum up before we move on..."
- "So the real question underneath all this is..."
- "Have I got that right?"

Quick prompts and encouragers · Keep them going

- "Say more?"
- "Go on."
- "How so?"
- "And then?"
- "What else?"
- "In what way?"
- "Mm — keep going."
- "So...?"

Simplifying and repairing · When the structure gets in the way

- "Let me say that more simply."
- "I think I over-structured that — here is the short version."
- "Ignore the framework for a second: what do you actually need?"
- "That may not be the right frame. Can we back up?"
- "What part of that helped, and what should we drop?"
- "I don't want the structure to get in the way of the real thing."

Emotional or high-stakes moments · Validate before you structure

- "That sounds really hard. We don't have to organise it yet."
- "Take your time — there is no rush to sort this into steps."
- "Before anything else: how are you doing with it?"
- "I just want to understand it properly before we go anywhere."
- "We can work out what to do once you have said it all."
- "You don't have to have this figured out to talk it through."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Using OARS as a visible script, so it sounds rehearsed.
Better: Using OARS silently to organise a concise response.
Best: Using OARS flexibly, then checking whether the person is clearer, more heard and better able to respond.
- Weak: Only asking questions, back to back, like an interview.
Better: Adding a reflection so they feel heard between questions.
Best: Letting reflections carry most of the weight, with questions used sparingly.
- Weak: Generic praise — "Great job."
Better: Naming what they did — "You worked through that carefully."
Best: Affirming the value behind it — "You clearly care about getting this right for them."

DECISION TREE

If They need speed

Skip to the shortest version — one reflection and a summary, no full loop.
"So the key point is the deadline. What do you want to do?"

If They are carrying emotion

Validate first; delay the structure until they feel heard.

"That sounds hard. Tell me what is going on."

If They want a story or worked example

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

"Can I walk you through how it went last time?"

If They need a decision or action

End on one clean next step.

"So the next move is to draft the email. Does that work?"

If They are already clear

Drop OARS — don't run steps they don't need.

"Sounds like you have got it. Anything you need from me?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Use OARS to make a contribution concise and land it, then check. — "Sounds like we agree on the timeline; the open question is budget. Have I read that right?"

Email or written message

Put each move into a short, scannable line rather than a wall of text. — "Quick summary, one question, one suggested next step — tell me if I have missed anything."

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback would help before you structure it. — "Would it help to talk it through, or would you rather I just gave you my read?"

Coaching a decision

Open and reflect before offering any view of your own. — "What is pulling you each way? ... So it is the risk, not the role, that is the snag."

Difficult conversation

One sentence per move, then pause and let them fill the space. — "I hear that it has felt unfair. What would make it feel fairer to you?"

Someone venting

Reflect and affirm; hold the summary until they are ready for it. — "That sounds exhausting. You have kept it together through a lot."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Urgent instruction or a rapid briefing
- Someone has directly asked for a straight answer or clear direction
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority
- Acute distress, grief or anger, where validation must come first
- A power imbalance where the structure could feel like control
- You would be running the four steps to look skilled rather than to help
- The person is already clear and just needs you to act

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the four moves

In a conversation you are part of or overhear, silently label each thing said as an Open question, Affirmation, Reflection, Summary — or none of them.

Day 2 — One open question

Replace one closed or leading question you would normally ask with a genuinely open one, and notice how much more you get back.

Day 3 — One honest affirmation

Once today, name something specific a person actually did well — their effort or a value it showed, not generic praise.

Day 4 — One reflection

Instead of replying with your own view, say back what you heard the person mean and let them confirm or correct it.

Day 5 — Summarise and check

At the end of a longer chat, pull the threads together in two sentences and ask "Have I got that right?"

Day 6 — Full loop, plain voice

Use all four moves in one real conversation without naming the framework, then afterwards cut anything that sounded rehearsed.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Notice one moment the structure is not helping, and use a recovery phrase to drop it and simplify on the spot.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use OARS to serve the person, or to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear by the end?
- Did I reflect or affirm, or did I only ask questions?
- Did I adapt when they needed something different?
- Did I keep it concise and drop the structure once it stopped helping?
- Did I leave the decision with them?